

MANDAR DEODHAR

LAYER AFTER LAYER BJP deputy CM Fadnavis

MAHARASHTRA/ BJP

THE BURDEN OF ALLIES

BJP leader. All this leaves the original BJP crop feeling a little disempowered.

A senior party MLA admits to discontent in the ranks, but says they have to grin and bear it: what could they do after the high command had decided on this course of action? "The party is doing it to ensure that (Narendra) Modi gets another term as prime minister. This narrative may help us overcome some of the disillusionment. Again, who knows how things will shape up after the general election?" he asks.

But there are inherent contradictions within the alliance. The NCP is seen as a party of the dominant Maratha community, while the BJP has been trying to build an organic base among the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), who form around 53 per cent of the state's population and are at odds with the Marathas over control of local power centres.

Though the wide expanse of the other backward groups (around 400 castes or classes) prevents the creation of a larger OBC identity, their consolidation can create a potent force. In the 2019 Lok Sabha election, the presence of the Prakash Ambedkar-led Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi (VBA) in the contest as a third front had led to the defeat of eight Congress/NCP candidates.

The BJP has over the decades groomed OBC leaders as a counterweight against the state's Maratha-dominated politics, and to tap into the aspirations of upwardly mobile caste groups. This is part of the 'Madhav formula' (an acronym for the Malis, Dhangars and Vanjaris) coined by Vasantrao Bhagwat, former general secretary of the state BJP, who groomed a generation of OBC leaders like Gopinath Munde (Vanjari), N.S. Pharande (Mali) and Anna Dange (Dhangar). This social engineering formula also helped the BJP shed its image of being a party of the privileged Brahmin-Bania castes.

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The Dhangars (shepherds) had been a focus area of late. The community is the state's second largest caste cluster (12-15 per cent) after the Maratha-Kunbi caste complex (31.5 per cent). The outreach to the Dhangars saw the BJP rope in community leaders like Gopichand Padalkar and Mahadeo Jankar of the Rashtriya Samaj Party (RSP). Padalkar, who unsuccessfully contested against Ajit from Baramati in 2019, and was made an MLC later, is known for his vitriolic attacks on the Pawars.